STARWEAVER®

Hands-On-Learning: Adversary Profiling & Deterrence Mapping

Learning Objectives

By the end of this activity, learners will be able to:



- Apply all three deterrence strategies — Deterrence by Denial, Deterrence by Punishment, and Deterrence by Resilience — to a specific threat actor profile.
- Analyze a historical cyber campaign to identify attacker tactics and motivations.
- Formulate a strategic matrix to communicate targeted deterrence recommendations to organizational leadership.

Description

In this hands-on activity, learners will transition from theoretical concepts of cyber deterrence to practical application. Set within the context of a modern threat intelligence team, learners will select a specific threat actor (Nation-State, Criminal Group, or Hacktivist) and design targeted deterrence measures. Learners will engage in individual strategy mapping and peer collaboration to refine their defensive postures.

Structure of the Activity: Title: Adversary Profiling & Deterrence Mapping

Tools used: Research browser, Strategy Matrix Template (Word/Excel)

Scenario

You are a Threat Intelligence Analyst for a global financial institution. Recent intelligence indicates a specific threat actor group is scouting your industry. Your CISO has asked you to profile this adversary and recommend how the organization can implement Deterrence by Denial (making the attack too hard), how governments might apply Deterrence by Punishment (raising the cost), and how the organization can leverage Deterrence by Resilience (reducing the attacker's expected payoff through rapid recovery) for this specific group.

Objective

Your goal is to build a complete three-pillar deterrence strategy tailored to a real threat actor. This exercise will help you apply the deterrence theories covered in the module, analyze adversary behavior from a historical campaign, and practice communicating strategic recommendations to organizational leadership using a structured matrix.



Instructions for learners

1. **Exploration:**
   - Select one threat actor group: Nation-State, Criminal Group, or Hacktivist.
   - Research a known historical campaign associated with this group using an open browser.
   - Note their primary tactics, tools, and motivations before moving to strategy mapping.

2 Strategy Mapping:

- Fill out the Strategy Matrix for your chosen actor.
- List two technical controls for Deterrence by Denial that would specifically thwart their known tactics.
- Identify one Deterrence by Punishment measure a government could apply to this actor (e.g., sanctions, legal indictment).
- Identify one Deterrence by Resilience measure — such as rapid backup restoration or continuity capability — that would reduce the attacker's expected payoff and make the attack less worthwhile.

3 Reflection:

Write one reason why deterring this specific actor is uniquely challenging compared to a traditional physical adversary.

Consider factors such as attribution difficulty, the actor's ideological motivations, or the absence of national assets to seize.

Organize Information Following This Structure for Peer Review:

- **Title Page:** Activity title, your name, date.
- **Adversary Profile:** Define the chosen actor, their typical motivations, and a brief summary of a historical campaign.
- **The Strategy Matrix:** Detail your three Deterrence by Denial technical controls and your one Deterrence by Punishment recommendation.
- **Reflections:** Explain the unique challenges of deterring this specific adversary in cyberspace.

Instructions for Documenting and Sharing the Project for Peer Review

Document the Project

- Use word processing software to create your project summary and reflections.
- Ensure all sections of the project document structure are completed.
- Proofread and edit your report for clarity and accuracy.

Share the Project

- Save your report in PDF format.
- Upload your documents to the “Peer Review” area in the course shell.
- Provide a brief description of your project in the submission post.

Peer Review

- Review the projects submitted by your peers.
- Provide constructive feedback and comments on the feasibility of their proposed controls and the completeness of their strategy matrix across all three deterrence pillars.

This activity gives learners a chance to apply the lesson by translating deterrence theory into a structured, actor-specific strategy that an organization and its government partners could realistically implement.